

MOVIE

Thor: Love and Thunder

★★★★☆ | It's clear that Marvel and Kevin Feige have no clue on how to proceed with Phase 4 of the MCU. Since the conclusion of Avengers: Endgame, it's all been downhill. The MTU (Marvel Television Universe) is an abject failure at basic storytelling and creating characters that the paying customer can root for. When it comes to the MCU, where do I even begin with this dumpster fire of a film? Love and Thunder starts with the genesis of Gorr the God Butcher, played by Christian Bale as he watches his daughter die in his arms and vows revenge on the gods for not helping. To be honest, Bale is the only actor who looks to be trying his best with the terrible script. The film then shifts tone into this humour that



kills any momentum that was built up. What follows is a confusing plot that sees Thor, Female Thor and Valkyrie go on whacky adventures to the land of the gods and beyond, always hitting us with the cringiest of one-liners and ending with another flashy, beam-in-the-sky finale. It's all so predictable and boring at this point that it's a wonder that people are excited about these substandard products.

The action look and feel so flat and fake that it's distracting. Watching Natalie Portman, replete with CGI arms fighting off monsters is hilarious. The visual effects look incredibly cheap and

the whole film just gives off the vibe of being shot on a sound stage with a green screen. There is nothing redeemable about this film and I wasted 2 hours of my life that I'll never get back. Even the costumes, which usually look relatively good, are basic cosplayer quality here. In fact, the entire film just gives off a cheap vibe. Love and Thunder is a \$185 million film and it looks like that money was spent on marketing and not on the actual film.

Love and Thunder is a failure on every level of filmmaking. It is boring, long and painfully unfunny. In fact, an autopsy is infinitely more entertaining than this pathetic excuse of a summer blockbuster film. You could go watch Top Gun: Maverick instead. At the very least, the people behind Maverick don't seem to hate the paying customer while the dolts behind the MCU seem to despise the very idea of fans and Love and Thunder is the latest expression of that very feeling.

—Andrew Lu

TV SERIES

Stranger Things Season 4: Volume 2

★★★★☆ | Stranger Things Season 4: Volume 2 kicks off right where Volume 1 left off – the beloved group of Hawkins natives are still split up in three different locations. However, they are inching closer and closer to a much-awaited reunion. The terror of Vecna / Henry Creel / 001 looms in the air as he gets closer to fulfilling his mission, which of course, threatens the world as they know it. Vecna, with his confounding and terrifying magic, proves to be a dark parallel to Eleven's powers and what she could have become had she not forged the friendships she has with Hopper (David Harbour), Mike (Finn Wolfhard), Max (Sadie Sink), and others. Many secrets are



unravelling and it leaves us convinced that the Duffers' had the storyline planned for a while now, since it all comes together so beautifully.

Volume 2 comprises two movie-length episodes, the second being a whopping 2 and a half hours! But boy, does time fly by! It is a true testament

to the pacing and interesting plot line of this season. Before any reunion happens, Eleven has a rematch of sorts with Vecna on an entirely different plane and this sequence provides some of the most breathtaking visuals of the series. There are losses this season, but some characters really do have plot armour, escaping the clasp of death multiple times now. Amidst all the terror, fear, and action, Stranger Things Season 4 Volume 2 still has delicate moments with hope and poignancy with staggering performances from the likes of Noah Schnapp (playing Will) and Sadie Sink (playing Max). We only wish these interactions were played out a bit longer, but there's probably much more to come in Season 5. Overall, Stranger Things is a full-blown phenomenon now, and for good reason. Here's to hoping Season 5 gives the series the conclusion it deserves and doesn't end up being another fiasco like GoT's final season was.

—Dhriti Datta